Appendices

Syllabus: Cultural Studies for Creative Professionals

Cultural Studies for Creative Professionals

Course Information
MSCH-CXXX
Semester: Spring 2020
Class Meets: Tuesday/Thursday 9:30am-10:45am; Screenings: Monday 7:00pm-10:00pm
Room: Franklin Hall FF212

Instructor Information
Sean Purcell
Office — Franklin Hall Stacks, Basement
Office Hours: Monday 1:00pm-2:00pm; Thursday 11:30am-12:30pm

Course Description

What goes into a creative project? This seminar and workshop will guide the student through the process of theorizing, researching, and proposing a creative work that is influenced by the field of cultural studies. By combining the workshop format with the seminar, Cultural Studies for Creative Professionals will teach students how to make artworks that are in dialogue with certain positions and arguments in the humanities. As a class, we will position ourselves between two ways of knowing, and learning to work as "theory/practitioners," to borrow Holly Willis' term. Standing at the in-between affords us, as Julain Bleeker, a professional designer who works at this same bridge, argues both

affords the "vernacular and the pragmatic. . . because it can operate with wit and paradox and a critical stance."

But how do we create a work that is both aesthetic and critical, that draws inspiration from the world and from cultural theory? This class presents a broad overview of the cultural studies field, with an emphasis on more contemporaneous issues. Rather than emphasizing the spectres that haunt the history of the field, we concern ourselves with concerns of identity, death, memory, and agency. Focusing on a crisis in the humanities that comes as a result of late capitalism, the increasing terror of global climate change, and a rejection of the humanist position in the enlightenment, this course engages with, and reveals the theoretical problems that intersect in contemporary cultural studies.

By engaging with these concerns, this class will ask the student to both engage critically, but also creatively and aesthetically to attempt to find practical ways of knowing and doing through subjects that interest the students. By the end of the semester, the student will have a beginning knowledge of a discourse surrounding one of their interests, tools to be able to continue research in that field, and a working proposal to apply for grants for as well as create a medium sized artistic project.

Course Objectives

1. Students will get a brief primer on interests in cultural studies related to identity, agency, and subject formation. This will focus on more contemporaneous sources with the interest in equipping students with a vocabulary to address issues from a variety of viewpoints.
2. Students will gain research skills, to better read and analyze academic texts, to better find sources for their own work, and to better critique those sources.
3. Students will learn to draft and plan creative projects iteratively, and with the support of their peers. They will learn how to respond to critique and feedback, and incorporate it into their future drafts.
4. Students will learn the process of previsualizing a new media, mixed media, installation, or film work. The final proposal will be designed to facilitate applications for grants, and should serve as the template for a future work.

Howardena Pindell. *Free White and 21.*

Class Format

We will meet twice a week, with each of our meetings functioning as either a seminar, workshop, or object lesson. While our main interests are in incorporating cultural studies into our creative work, it is necessary to work with the material in different ways.

Every week will have one **seminar**, a discussion led by the professor to cover key points in every article, to help distill the information for the students. These will be conversations, where students should bring up their concerns, their criticisms, their confusion with the texts

in question. Given the difficulty of these texts, and the breadth of material we are covering this semester, these texts will be applied to the next session's workshop or object lesson class.

Workshops are, as in the tradition of creative teaching, designed for students to get a hands on approach to the ideas in class. Some of these workshops will involve addressing key material in the previous week, and others are larger stepping stones toward the final project. Each workshop will require some form of work to be completed in advance—a writing exercise, a draft of part of the proposal, a pitch. For each of these sessions, we will be learning how to talk about these topics in the context of our own work. While the credit for each of these small assignments stands for the majority of the final grade, this will be determined more so by the completeness of the assignment, and not necessarily the quality. *These projects are drafts and will be graded accordingly.*

In addition to these first two class types, we will occasionally have **object lessons**. These classes are meant to learn how to apply difficult material to creative works, to either reverse engineer how a work came together, to better explain a creative object, or to explain the theoretical material more fully. Some of these lessons will involve reading ahead of time, but will usually only mean one or two chapters of additional work for the week. In the few times we have screenings, we will meet on Monday evenings to screen the films.

Readings

As part of a seminar, students are expected to read the material in full, and be ready to talk about it class. We will be spending a good deal of time during the semester working on academic reading skills, and it is paramount to the kind of practice this class intends to teach. A large portion of the participation credit will depend on being able to participate during the seminar discussions, as a lively discussion is very important to facilitating the learning of this complicated material.

A Side Note: It is not expected that you will have full comprehension of these materials. We read for seminar as part of a beginning process of learning a text. This means that being confused, or having questions about a certain text is as necessary as being able to talk about it. Please bring these concerns to the class, and we can work through them as best we can over the day's session.

Workload

This class is designed to require about 5 hours of work outside of class each week (roughly 2 hours of reading and 3 hours of writing on average). It has been designed to work iteratively towards a proposal, and each of the assignments will continue to build towards that final project. As such, some weeks might be too much to handle.

While I expect on time completion of the material, I understand that this is a learning environment. If you are having trouble please talk to me. I want to help in any way I can.

Primary Texts and Supplementary Material

There is no textbook for the course. We will be reading small sections from many books. We will be reading an extended section from the following book. I recommend everyone pick it up to begin reading as soon as you are able.

Wu Ming-Yi. *The Man with the Compound Eyes* trans. Darryl Sterk. (Vintage Books, 2014; orig. 2011).

Course Assessment

In Class Participation — 20% of Final Grade

Students are expected to come to class prepared to discuss the assigned texts, and be ready to respond to their peers' creative work. It is vital for the class for our discussions to be active, as we will use the seminar time to work through difficult theoretical texts. Students will be asked to participate at least once during each class period (I will be taking notes), as it is important to learn to speak in an academic seminar space.

I know it is difficult at times to be able to participate in these environments, and that some students have trouble voicing their opinions, but for the sake of professional development I believe it is important to get out of one's comfort zone and engage with the discussion.

If you are having trouble with this, I am always happy to speak in private during my office hours, or at a time that best suits you.

Weekly Assignments — 50% of Final Grade

The implicit goal of these weekly assignments are to get your final proposal in order. Since the final proposal is creative work, and it is very difficult to grade creative work without personal bias being involved, a majority of the grade has been placed on the iterative elements leading to the final project. The majority of each assignment's grades will be placed on whether the assignment is done on time, and if it fulfills the minimum requirements expected.

I am not expecting perfect work for any of these step by step assignments; instead, the design takes into consideration small, iterative steps with an emphasis on meeting deadlines, and working through problems as they arise.

Again, if you are having trouble with this aspect of the class, please feel free to message me, and we can talk during my office hours.

Final Proposal — 20% of Final Grade

Students will turn in a proposal for a medium sized artistic project (a 10-20 minute film, a series of artworks, a small installation). For this proposal, the following materials will be required:

Artist Statement: 1-2 Pages

This essay will explain who you are as an artist. Where do you come from? What drives your creative work? Who inspires you? Why are you doing this project? Tell us a story about your life, how you got here, and where you plan to go with this project.

Introduction: 2-3 Pages

At this point you have introduced yourself. Now you will introduce the project. Why are you making it? With whom are you working? What are the specific things the reader needs to know before they get to the synopsis?

Synopsis: At least 5 pages (Floorplans, sketches, previsualizations also work.)

Describe the project in detail. This means that if you are making a documentary, you should be able to tell the story you are thinking of making, and describe how it would cut together. If you are making a narrative film, you should have a script. If you are doing an installation,

you should describe what is there, along with detailed floorplans and sketches.

Intellectual Rationale: At least 10 Pages

Take the material we have been working on, and the material you have been reading in addition to this course and synthesize it. Who do you agree with? What ideas make you think about your art? What do you disagree with? In what way does the scholarly work inform or contradict the work you make?

Budget

How much will the project cost. I am not looking for a detailed, exhaustive budget, but I would like you to think through the materials necessary, the personnel needed, and the kind of expenses that would be necessary to finish the work.

Course Policies

Attendance:

Unless you have a documented medical excuse, missing class, especially because class meets only once a week, is not an option. Attendance is mandatory and non-negotiable for every class. Each and every undocumented absence from class will severely affect your participation grade.

Plagiarism:

Using ideas and words from published work, online materials, or other students' projects without accurate attribution will be severely punished, and may result in an automatic grade of "F" for the course. Please refer to the section on academic misconduct in your Schedule of Classes for the codes and policies governing plagiarism.

Deadlines:

You are expected to turn in all the assignments on time and during our class period unless otherwise noted; late work will not be accepted or graded. Missed assignments can only be made up in case of an emergency, and documentation (doctor's letter) must be provided in such situations. Any other occasion for absence from class or lateness with assignments —visiting family, travel plans, concerts, and social obligations — are not considered sufficient reasons for make-up work.

Your Personal Wellbeing and Health:

Students can face challenges in their personal lives, and it is a sign of great strength to acknowledge that and ask for help. As the instructor, I want to help guide you to appropriate resources if you come to me in confidence. You can always go directly to Indiana University's Counseling & Psychological Services (CAPS) at the Health Center for support (812-855-5711). CAPS can help students on many issues, including depression, anxiety, relationship issues, sexual assault, feelings of inadequacy, substance abuse and difficulty adjusting to the routines and expectations of student life. More information about CAPS is available here: http://healthcenter.indiana.edu/counseling/index.shtml (Links to an external site.).

Accommodations for Religious Observances:

Indiana University respects the right of all students to observe their religious holidays. However, it is your responsibility to notify me in advance. Please notify me of expected absences for religious observances by the end of the second week of class.

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities:
I will make every attempt to accommodate qualified students with disabilities (e.g. mental health, learning, chronic health, physical, hearing, vision, neurological, etc.). Please establish your eligibility for support through Indiana University's Office of Disability Services for Students. If you have a documented learning disability that may affect your work in this class, I request you to provide me appropriate documentation by the end of the second week of class. Further information about university policies and procedures regarding learning disabilities is available at https://studentaffairs.indiana.edu/disability-services-students/

Part 1 : Why Do We Work?

Week 1: Introduction, and How to Read a Critical Article

Tuesday, January 14th — Seminar: Introductions, Syllabus, and Rationale

Tina Takemoto. "Open Wounds" in *Thinking Through the Skin* eds. Sara Ahmed and Jackie Stacey. (London & New York: Routledge, 2001), 105-123.

Holly Willis. "Introduction: The State of Things," in *Fast Forward: The Future(s) of the Cinematic Arts.* (London & New York: Wallflower Press, 2016), 1-21.

Thursday, January 16th —Seminar: Critiquing an Academic Article

Laud Humphreys. "Tearoom Trade: Impersonal Sex in Public Places," in *Sociology Full Circle* ed. William Feigelman. (New York: Praeger Publishers, 1972), 29-54.

Week 2: *Eros* and *Praxis*

Tuesday, January 21st — Seminar: Praxis

Paulo Freire. "Chapter 3," in *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*. (New York: Continuum, 2005), 87-124.

bell hooks. "Eros, Eroticism, and the Pedagogical Process," and "Ecstasy: Teaching and Learning without Limits," in *Teaching to Transgress: Education as the Practice of Freedom*. (New York: Routledge, 1994), 191 - 208.

Susan Sontag. "Against Interpretation,"in *Against Interpretation and Other Essays*. (New York, 1966), pp. 3-14

Thursday, January 23rd — Workshop: Proposing Ideas

DUE IN CLASS

Do some preliminary research on an object. Pull 5 sources on your topic and describe the issue through those sources. Roughly 1-2 pages. What are they saying? Do you agree with them?

Week 3: Viewing through the *Camera Obscura*

Tuesday, January 28th — Seminar: Viewing through the *Camera Obscura*

Karl Marx. Parts 1 and 2 of *The Critique of the German Ideology*. Web Marx.

Optional: Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels. Sections 1 and 2 of *Manifesto of the Communisit Party.*

Thursday, January 30th — Workshop: Seeing Ideology and Perspective

DUE IN CLASS

Academic Article Questionnaire of a chosen article on your subject area of interest. (Roughly 1-2 pages)

Week 4: What Course? Dis-Course

Tuesday, February 4th — Seminar: Power, Discourse, and the Body

Michel Foucault."Part Four: The Deployment of Sexuality," chapters 1, 2 & 3 in *The History of Sexuality Volume 1: An Introduction* trans. Robert Hurley. (New York: Vintage Books, 1990; orig. 1978), 77-114.

Bruno Latour and Steve Woolgar. "From Order to Disorder," "The Creation of Order out of Disorder," and "Postscript to Second Edition," in *Laboratory Life: The Social Construction of Scientific Facts*. (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1986; orig. 1979) 15-42, 235-258, 273-285.

Thursday, February 6th — Workshop: Sketching a Discourse

DUE IN CLASS

Bibliography Draft: 20-30 Sources.
You do not need to have read all of these sources. These will form the beginning of your reading list for the academic rationale.

Section 2: Who Are You?

Week 5 — Ideology: Hailing the Subject

Tuesday, February 11th — Workshop: Why Do We Work on Specific Subjects?

DUE IN CLASS

Short Writing Assignment: Who are you? 2-4 pages.
Why do you work? Describe two past art projects, or theoretical projects in relation to your interests. Do these projects have anything that is similar to one another? What draws you to a certain subject or formation? Is there something about these subjects that give you energy, purpose, or excitement?

PLEASE BRING:

An old, completed art project as an example of your work, should we need it in class.

Thursday, February 13th — Seminar: An Introduction to Ideology

Louis Althusser. "Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses (Notes towards an Investigation)" in *Lenin and Philosophy* trans. Ben Brewster. (Monthly Review Press, 1971), 127-181.

Week 6 — Hegemony: Dearticulating/Rearticulating

Tuesday, February 18th — Workshop: Reflecting on Past Institutions and Ideologies

DUE IN CLASS

Short Writing Assignment: Institution Reflection 2-5 Pages.
Describe the institutions of your life. What schools did you attend? Were you, or are you in a religious institution? Where have you worked? Where have you spent your time? Reflecting on each of these, how did they inform the way you think? Can you be critical of any of these institutions? Can you argue against them or for them in specific regards? How do these institutions inform your work?

Thursday, February 20th — Seminar: An Introduction to Gramsci

Chantal Mouffe. "Hegemony and Ideology in Gramsci" in *Gramsci and Marxist Theory*, ed. Chantal Mouffe. (London & New York: Routledge, 2014; orig. 1979), 168-204.

Frank Wilderson III. "Gramsci's Black Marx: Whither the Slave in Civil Society," in *Social Identities* 9(2). (2003), 225-240.

Week 7 — Gender

Tuesday, February 25th — Workshop: Who Are You?

DUE IN CLASS

Short Writing Assignment — Artist's Statement Draft 1: 1-2 Pages. Summarize yourself. Why do you do the work you do? What in your past influences the work you do? What conversation are you engaging in? Describe your work in detail.

Thursday, February 27th — Seminar: Power, Discourse, and the Body

Jennifer C. Nash. "Re-thinking Intersectionality," *Feminist Review* 89(1). (2008), 1-15.

Mari Jo Buhle. "In the Age of the Vanishing Subject," in *Feminism and Its Discontents*. (Cambridge: Harvard, 1998), 318-358.

Zoe Samudzi. "Who Are You and What Do You Really Know? Gaslighting and Dolezalean logic," *The New Inquiry*. (May 13 2017), web.

Saba Mahmood. "Feminist Theory, Embodiment, and the Docile Agent: Some Reflections on the Egyptian Islamic Revival," *Cultural Anthropology*, 16(2). (2008), 202-236.

Week 8 — Race

Tuesday, March 3rd — Object Lesson: Feminisms, Intersections, Discourses

Howardena Pin/dell. *Free, White and 21*. Video. 12:15 min. 1980.

Pharmacopoeia. *Cradle to Grave*. Installation. Linen, pharmaceuticals, found objects. 2003. See: http://www.pharmacopoeia-art.net/articles/in-sickness-and-in-health/

Please Read Before Class:

Adrienne Rich. "Diving into the Wreck," in *Diving into the Wreck* (New York & London: W. W. Norton and Company, 2013; orig. 1973), 22-24.

Adrienne Rich. "Power," in *Dream of a Common Language: Poems 1974-1977*. (New York & London: W. W. Norton and Company, 2013; orig. 1978), 3.

Thursday, March 5th — Seminar: Blackness/Whiteness

Franz Fanon. "The Fact of Blackness," in *Black Skin White Masks* trans. Charles Lam Markmann. (London: Pluto Press, 1986; orig 1952), 109-140.

Richard Dyer. "The Matter of Whiteness," in *White Privilege: Essential Readings at the Other Side of Racism* ed. Paula Rothenberg. (2005), 9-14.

Karen E Fields and Barbara J. Fields. "Introduction," *Racecraft: The Soul of Inequality in American Life*. (New York: Verso, 2014), 1-24.

Week 9 — Sexuality, Violence, and Response to Injustice

Tuesday, March 10th — Object Lesson: Systems of Racial Violence

Krista Thompson, "Art, Fiction, History," *Perspectives* (2017), 1-14.

Saidiya Hartman. "Venus in Two Acts," in *Small Axe* 12(2). (June 2008), 1-14

Thursday, March 12th — Seminar: Gender, Construction, and Intersection

Eve Sedgewick. "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading, or, You're So Paranoid, You Probably Think this Essay is About You," in *Touching Feeling: Affect, Pedagogy, Performativity*. (Durham & London: Duke University Press, 2003), 123-151.

Ann Cvetkovich. "Introduction" and "The Everyday Life of Queer Trauma," in *An Archive of Feelings: Trauma, Sexuality, and Lesbian Public Cultures*. (Durham & London: Duke University Press, 2003), 1-48.

SPRING BREAK — No Class!

Week 10 — Recapitulation: Identity, Praxis, and Feeling

Monday, March 23rd (7:00 PM - 10:00 PM) — **Screening**: Derek Jarman. *Blue*. 1993.

Tuesday, March 24th — Object Lesson: Angst, Abstraction, and Artistic Practice

DUE IN CLASS

Annotated Bibliography of 7-10 sources related to your project. Each source should have a ~250 word summary, including its method, argument and significance to your project. This will be the outline for your academic rationale draft.

Thursday, March 26th — Seminar: Intersections of Practice, Affect, Identity

Tina Campt. "Listening to Images: An Exercise in Counterintuition" and "Quiet Soundings: The Grammar of Black Futurity," in *Listening to Images*. (Durham & London: Duke University Press, 2017), 1-46.

Part 3: What is At Stake?

Week 11 — The Power of Death

Tuesday, March 31st — Workshop: Proposing Projects, and Pitching the Self

DUE IN CLASS (Two Assignments)

Artist's Statement Second Draft. 1-2 pages. Reflecting on feedback from the instructor, and the discussion of race, gender, and sexuality, revise your artist's statement.

Synopsis Draft 1. 1-2 pages. Write a synopsis of the project you wish to do. Describe what materials which you plan to work. Describe a rough idea of what the final project would look like. Describe the arenas of conversation which you wish to engage. Be prepared to discuss your project at some length (5-10 minutes).

Tuesday, April 2nd — Seminar: Nocturnal Humanism

Achille Mbembe. "Exit from Democracy," "Necropolitics" in *Necropolitics*, trans. Steven Corcoran. (Durham & London: Duke University Press, 2019; orig. 2016), 9-41, 66-92

Week 12 — Horizontal Ontologies

Tuesday, April 7th — Seminar: Objects and Agency

Bruno Latour. "On Actor-Network Theory: A Few Clairfications Plus More Than a Few Complications," *Soziale Welt* 47. (1996), 369-381.

Graham Harman. "Object-Oriented Ontology," in *The Palgrave Handbook of Posthumanism in Film and Television* ed. M Hauskeller, et al. (London: 2016), 401-409.

Jane Bennett. "Systems and Things: A Response to Graham Harman and Timothy Morton," *New Literary History* 43(2). (2012), 225-233.

Thursday, April 9th — Object Lesson: Objects and their Agencies

Franz Kafka. "The Cares of a Family Man."

DUE IN CLASS

Introduction and Synopsis Draft 1 Due. 5-7 pages. Build upon the synopsis you wrote earlier. Go into detail about the project you are doing. What is informing your work? How will we experience it? What is influencing your project formally? What are the specific methods you will be going about making your work? Be prepared to discuss the project in detail again, and discuss how your project has changed over the course of the semester.

Week 13 — The Anthropocene

Tuesday, April 14th — Seminar: Humanities and the Anthropocene

Chakrabarty, Dipesh. "Humanities in the Anthropocene: The Crisis of an Enduring Kantian Fable," *New Literary History* 47(2-3). (Summer 2016), 377-397.

Latour, Bruno. "Agency at the Time of the Anthropocene," *New Literary History* 45(1). (Winter 2014): 1-18.

Thursday, April 16th — Object Lesson: Art in the Anthropocene

Wu Ming-Yi. *The Man with the Compound Eyes* trans. Darryl Sterk. (Vintage Books, 2014; orig. 2011). Selections.

Week 14 — Vital Objects

Tuesday, April 21st — Thursday — Seminar: Vitalism and Agency

Jane Bennet. *Vibrant Matter*: *A Political Ecology of Things*. (Durham: Duke University Press, 2013). Vii-38, 62-93.

Thursday, April 23rd — Seminar: Being Undone: Identity, Death, and the Agency of Compost

Jill H. Casid. "Doing things with being undone," Journal of Visual Culture 18(1). (2019), 30-52.

DUE AT THE END OF THE DAY

Academic Rationale Draft Due. 5-7 pages. Working with both sources from your annotated bibliography, as well as new sources, and sources from the class, argue how your project both uses ideas expressed in the written sources, and how they push against or critique these ideas. Who do you agree with? Who do you disagree with? Why? How does your art participate in a dialogue with those academic sources?

Week 15 — No Class

Finals — Proposals Due Thursday, May 7th at 11:59 PM. Please email them to me.